

Figure 6: Parali S. Nellaiyappa Pillai

The thin line that divided VOC's various Swadeshi activities is attested to by the fact that Su. Kandaswamy Pillai, manager of SSNCo took charge of the Nesavu Salai, a Swadeshi weaving enterprise established by VOC.[5] Kandaswamy Pillai had in fact left a well-paid job in the port office to join in Swadeshi work.[6]

High court lawyer and Tamil scholar S. Somasundara Bharati's appointment as manager of SSNCo in July 1907 was also VOC's doing.[7] Though designated only as manager, Bharati signed one of the two surviving share certificates as secretary a month later. The monthly salary of Rs 125 that he drew would have been a fraction of what he would have made as a lawyer.[8] Born in 1879, Somasundara Bharati (Figure 7) was a childhood friend of the poet C. Subramania Bharati—in fact, both received the title 'Bharati' on the same occasion. On graduating from Madras Christian College and then qualifying for a law degree, he began practice in Tuticorin barely a year before the launch of the Swadeshi shipping company. VOC and Somasundara Bharati shared both professional and intellectual interests, for Bharati was a Tamil scholar as well. Somasundara Bharati's lifelong association with the Indian National Congress dates to the